

Political and Constitutional Development in Pakistan (1947–1969)

Introduction

- • Period marked by crisis and institutional formation
- • Partition, migration, weak economy
- • Simultaneous state and nation building
- • Frequent constitutional breakdowns
- • Rise of bureaucracy and military influence

Inheritance at Independence (1947)

- • Limited financial resources
- • Few administrative offices
- • Lack of trained personnel
- • Refugee influx of millions
- • Geographical separation of East & West Pakistan

Immediate Administrative Challenges

- • Establishing ministries and departments
- • Restoring law and order
- • Refugee settlement and rehabilitation
- • Setting up capital at Karachi
- • Building civil services from scratch

Role of Quaid-i-Azam

- • Central authority in early years
- • Maintained unity and discipline
- • Guided constitutional direction
- • Emphasized democracy and minority rights
- • Death in 1948 created leadership vacuum

Leadership Crisis After 1948

- • Death of Jinnah
- • Assassination of Liaquat Ali Khan
- • Weak successors
- • Political instability
- • Bureaucracy gained dominance

Objectives Resolution 1949

- • Sovereignty belongs to Allah
- • Authority exercised through elected representatives
- • Islamic principles with democracy
- • Foundation for future constitutions
- • Debate on religion and state

Constitution Making Difficulties

- • Representation dispute: East vs West
- • Parliamentary vs presidential system
- • Federal vs unitary structure
- • Islamic vs secular principles
- • Delays weakened democracy

Political Instability (1951–1956)

- • Frequent cabinet changes
- • Governor General's interference
- • Dismissal of governments
- • Weak Muslim League
- • Loss of public confidence

First Constitution 1956

- • Parliamentary system
- • Federal structure
- • Islamic Republic status
- • Fundamental rights
- • Abrogated within two years

Why the 1956 Constitution Failed

- • Weak parties
- • Factional politics
- • Administrative dominance
- • Lack of democratic culture
- • Executive interference

Civil–Military Bureaucratic Alliance

- • Strong civil service
- • Organized military
- • Marginalization of politicians
- • Centralized decision making
- • Foundation for authoritarian rule

Martial Law 1958

- • Iskander Mirza dissolved constitution
- • General Ayub Khan took control
- • Suspension of political activity
- • Beginning of military rule
- • Turning point in political history

Ayub Khan's Reforms

- • Basic Democracies system
- • Local government structure
- • Economic planning and growth
- • Controlled political participation
- • Presidential governance

1962 Constitution

- • Presidential system
- • Indirect elections
- • Strong executive powers
- • Limited political freedoms
- • Reduced parliamentary role

Economic Development under Ayub

- • Industrialization
- • Green Revolution
- • Foreign aid inflow
- • Growth of urban middle class
- • But regional inequality increased

East–West Pakistan Tensions

- • Population majority in East
- • Less political power
- • Unequal resource distribution
- • Growing grievances
- • Rise of Bengali nationalism

Language Controversy

- • Urdu declared national language
- • Bengali majority opposed decision
- • 1952 Language Movement
- • Cultural resistance
- • Strengthened regional identity

One Unit Scheme 1955

- • West Pakistan merged into one province
- • Aimed for parity with East
- • Reduced provincial autonomy
- • Generated resentment
- • Failed to promote unity

Federalism and Provincial Autonomy Issues

- • Central control of finance and defense
- • Limited provincial powers
- • Demands for decentralization
- • Conflicts between center and provinces
- • Persistent constitutional problem

Political Opposition to Ayub

- • Restrictions on parties
- • Fatima Jinnah's challenge
- • Student protests
- • Labor unrest
- • Public dissatisfaction increased

Fall of Ayub Khan 1969

- • Mass protests nationwide
- • Loss of legitimacy
- • Transfer of power to Yahya Khan
- • Martial law continued
- • Democratic transition delayed

Overall Assessment (1947–1969)

- • Slow institutional development
- • Weak democracy
- • Military dominance
- • Regional alienation
- • Unresolved constitutional questions

Key Lessons

- • Strong institutions are essential
- • Federalism must respect diversity
- • Political participation builds stability
- • Economic equality strengthens unity
- • Democracy prevents authoritarianism